

Секрет счастья — в игре в баскетбол. Спросите у этого 81-летнего мужчины



Пикап-баскетбол предлагает самый ценный ресурс современной жизни: возможность успокоить разум и просто быть. Иллюстрация: Дэн Голдфарб / The Athletic; iStock



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Эта статья — часть рубрики Peak, в которой The Athletic рассказывает о психологической стороне спорта. Подпишитесь на рассылку Peak [здесь](#).

Ричи Цвайгенхафт раз в неделю играет в баскетбол с любителями, и когда его просят описать свою игру, он обычно называет три имени: Магси Богс, Джон Стоктон и Дэйв Тварджик.

Рост Цвайгенхафта — 5 футов 4 дюйма, поэтому он черпал вдохновение в Боге, самом низкорослом игроке в истории НБА. Он также любит отдавать передачи, что объясняет его восхищение Стоктоном, лидером по количеству результативных передач в истории НБА. Его восхищение Твардзиком, жестким и умным игроком «Портленд Трэйл Блэйзер» в 1970-х, носит более глубокий характер. Но этому есть хорошее объяснение.

Цвайгенхафту 81 год.

Он начал регулярно играть в баскетбол в начале 1970-х, когда учился в докторантуре Калифорнийского университета в Санта-Крузе. С тех пор он практически не прекращал играть. Последние 51 год он организует еженедельные матчи в Гилфорд-колледже в Гринсборо, штат Северная Каролина, где он является почетным профессором кафедры психологии.

Игра в Гилфорде, вероятно, является одним из самых продолжительных непрерывных турниров по пикап-баскетболу в Америке. Она пережила девять президентов. Игрокам в основном от 60 до 70 лет. Несколько лет назад, когда игроки стали медленнее двигаться, а темп игры снизился, Цвайгенхафт придумал новое название для лиги: «Стариковский мяч».

«Каждый раз, когда у меня день рождения, я думаю: *Боже мой, мне так повезло, что я все еще играю*, — сказал мне Цвайгенхафт. — Никто не знает, сколько мне осталось».

Я обратился к Цвайгенхафту в надежде, что он поможет мне справиться с надвигающимся жизненным кризисом. В начале этого года я играл в

Из-за этого неудобного растения связки на моем правом колене растянулись до нежелательной степени, что на несколько недель ограничило мою способность ходить и бегать. Это был неприятный опыт.

До моего 40-летия оставалось всего пару месяцев, и я впервые осознала: я не смогу играть вечно.

Однажды я попытался объяснить другу, почему моя игра в пикап в 21:30 по понедельникам может быть самыми радостными 90 минутами за всю неделю. Это был источник творчества и импровизации, высокоинтенсивная тренировка, которая вырабатывала эндорфины и снимала тревожность, коллективное состояние потока, в котором мы все полностью и осознанно жили настоящим моментом.

Казалось, что это самый ценный дар современной жизни: возможность успокоить свой разум и просто быть. Игра в баскетбол на площадке была прямым путем к мгновенному просветлению.

“It has a therapeutic quality in that respect,” Zweigenhaft agreed.

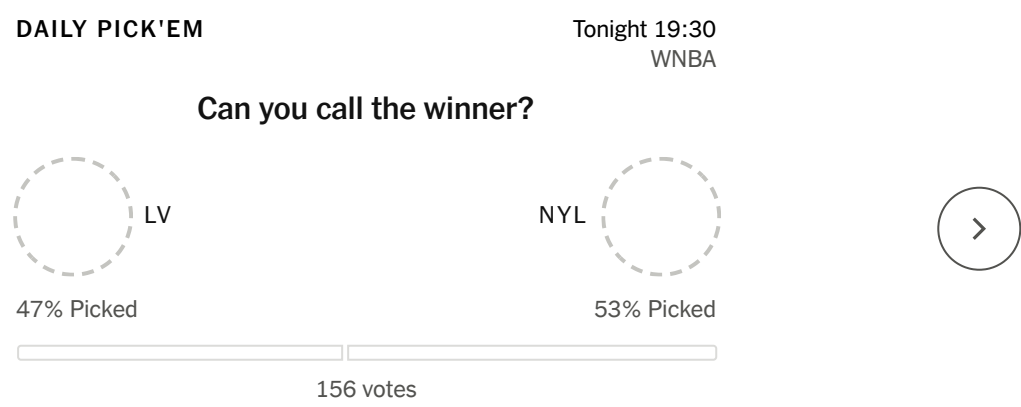
That’s why I reached out to Zweigenhaft. After 50 years, I figured he would have some wisdom about this thing we shared.

perfect extra pass.

When you are 81 years old, there are certain things you cannot do on a basketball court. Here is one: Zweigenhaft cannot shoot a pull-up jump shot.

He used to be able to stop on a dime and unleash a feathery jumper. But as the years piled up, his muscles stopped cooperating. He could shoot, or he could drive, but he could not do them simultaneously.

Other than that, the Guilford game is surprisingly lively. It’s still twice a week. The average age is around 64. The players have stopped counting hip and knee replacements, and over the years, the run has lost participants to injury, retirement and, on occasion, death.



Yet, just a few weeks ago, Zweigenhaft was on the floor inside Ragan-Brown Fieldhouse, matched up with a smallish guard who played fierce defense, crashed the boards and generally played with the aggression of Jose Alvarado of the New York Knicks. Which, of course, made sense.

“He is 40 years younger (than me),” Zweigenhaft said.

Jalen Brunson's "constant" that helped him level up throughout his career
Elise Devlin

The most amazing part of the game is its longevity, and Zweigenhaft credits a slogan he borrowed from the Chinese during the Cold War: “Friendship First, Competition Second.”

TOP LEAGUE CONTENT

“We didn’t have many lawyers,” Zweigenhaft said. “That’s another reason the game lasted so long.”

It began in 1975, when Zweigenhaft was a fresh-faced faculty member researching the American power elite. At first, it was just a classic noontime pickup run, the players gathering inside an old-school gym nicknamed the Crackerbox, which looked like something out of “Hoosiers” and featured the kind of soft rims that every player loves.

By the mid-1980s, the run was in a new facility and featured three full-court games, three times per week.

In a way, it was a thriving community experiment that academics call a third place, a social space separate from home or work. It was a culture unto itself, complete with its own rules, norms and language.

In fact, it was exactly the kind of culture that interested a sociologist in Chicago.



Members of the Guilford game used to play in a gym nicknamed the Crackerbox. Courtesy of Craig Chappelow

In the early 1990s, Jason Jimerson was a doctoral student in sociology at the University of Chicago who had spent the previous decade playing pickup basketball on college campuses.

Inspired by his personal experiences and a book about basketball culture, Jimerson set out to begin the first qualitative academic research on pickup hoops, examining games in suburban Chicago and West Lafayette, Ind.

There is a reason sociologists have spent decades studying pickup basketball. The sport is naturally physical, aggressive and competitive. The stakes are clear: The winner usually gets to stay on the court and play again. Yet, the activity is orderly, efficient and overwhelmingly positive, the players almost solely concerned with the collective whole.

“What makes a good party is not just that you have fun but that other people have fun as well,” said Jimerson, now a sociology professor at Franklin College.

The weekly game I play in New York fits the description: it has existed in some form for more than two decades and years before I started playing. The roster is in constant churn, though the bloated email list exists as an unofficial archive of former players. (When an old commissioner retired last year, one former player replied to the thread that he had not played in five years and had no plans to return. But he still wanted the emails.)

performative focus on process over results. When a player finds themselves open and misses a shot, you will hear a chorus of teammates, ready to uplift them.

Good look.

Keep shooting.

“One of the things that’s really interesting about human beings is how we can work together as a group to help individuals stand out,” Jimerson said. “That’s transcendent.”

A musician with an interest in jazz, Jimerson came to realize there was an almost meditative quality to a pickup basketball game. In the early 1970s, the psychologist Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi discovered the “flow” idea, which described a particular state of heightened consciousness in which people were so immersed in an activity that they lost all semblance of the self.

What made pickup basketball unique was not just that it was an effective tool for entering a flow state. It was that, like jazz, it was an activity in which people could experience a state of collective flow, which has been found to enhance creativity and create stronger social bonds.

“What makes a game really fun is when you play against people who make you play better,” Jimerson said. “That’s collective efficacy. That’s when collective flow occurs.”

York Knicks for *The Athletic*. Despite working at the same company for years, James and I had never met. But within minutes, I picked out an aesthetic quality in his style of play, obvious to anyone who has spent a lifetime playing basketball. James had an old-school game — fluid pace, a crafty handle, great court vision.

Moments later, when James subtly looked off a pass and hit a cutter for a layup, I didn't have to say anything.

I felt like I'd known him for years.

Zweigenhaft didn't set out to play basketball until he was 81. When he hit 70, he had no illusions he would be playing at 80.

"I said, 'Uh-oh, you're 70,'" Zweigenhaft said. "You used to be 60."

He kept seeing friends who had to give up the game. They missed the exercise, the physicality and the source of creative expression. But more than anything, Zweigenhaft could see they missed "that whole social experience."

Not long after talking to Zweigenhaft, I found myself playing in a pickup game on a Sunday morning in Lower Manhattan. One of my teammates was a guy named Jack Appleby, a 38-year-old former small-college basketball player who was once

When he reconnected with the sport in adulthood, he realized how much he needed the teamwork and cognitive stimulation he found on the basketball court.

“I get to use my brain to problem solve live on a basketball court, which I really love,” Appelby told me. “And I get tiny, defined victories for myself.”

A few years ago, on a lark, he launched an Instagram page with a simple gimmick: “How to Hoop Forever.” He had considered the so-called male loneliness epidemic — the rising rates of isolation and the dwindling social engagement from younger generations. He started offering advice to people he met in New York City: Have you thought about pickup basketball?

On the day I met Appleby, his back was hurting severely. After a game, he sprawled on the floor to stretch, which was a good reminder of our basketball mortality. It may not be possible to hoop forever, but there is a reason why people like Zweigenhaft cannot stop.

The game fosters social connection and individual artistry. It helps us understand our own limitations.

“It helps me appreciate the life I’m living,” Zweigenhaft said.

He lives by a simple rule, one shared by the musician Warren Zevon as he died of cancer in the early 2000s.

“You put more value on every minute,” Zevon said. “You’re reminded to enjoy every sandwich.”

Zweigenhaft had just played basketball that day. One of the other guys in the Guilford game had spent the day in the hospital.

“So as I went to play,” he said, “I was thinking about him being in the hospital, and I was thinking: *Enjoy every sandwich. If you don’t play well today, don’t give yourself a hard time.*”

The joy is in the attempt, in the ability to go out and play. So Zweigenhaft is going to keep playing until he cannot anymore.

Rustin Dodd is a senior writer for Peak, The Athletic's new vertical covering sports leadership, personal development and success. He joined The Athletic in 2018 after nine years at The Kansas City Star.

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